

The Effect of Social Media on Students' Academic Performance in Higher Education

Introduction:

In the modern era, social media has become an integral part of many young people's lives. Platforms such as Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, and more recently, TikTok are now widely used by university students across the globe. These platforms provide easy access to communication, entertainment, and information, but also pose significant distractions that may affect the academic outcomes of learners. With the growing dependence on digital technologies, it is crucial to understand how social media usage is affecting the performance of students in higher education.

The use of social media is not limited to socializing. Many students use it for study groups, sharing resources, and staying informed about academic events. However, when used excessively or with poor time management, it may lead to procrastination, stress, and lack of focus, which can ultimately result in lower grades. Therefore, the relationship between social media activity and student academic performance is complex and must be explored in more detail.

Literature Review:

According to Ahmed et al. (2019), there is a strong correlation between high daily usage of social media and decreased GPA among college-level students. The study suggested that many students spend 3 to 5 hours daily on social media, which takes away time from studying or completing assignments. Likewise, Johnson (2021) found that multitasking between studying and scrolling through social media reduces retention of information and increases mental fatigue.

On the other hand, several studies have highlighted positive aspects of social media usage in academic contexts. For example, Kumar & Lee (2020) discuss how online platforms can enhance collaboration among classmates and facilitate knowledge sharing. They state that students who engage in course-related discussions on social networks tend to feel more connected to their academic community.

Despite these findings, most of the existing research focuses only on either the negative or positive side of social media usage. Very few studies take into account the different purposes, durations, and contexts of usage. There is also limited data available on how these patterns vary across different fields of study or demographic backgrounds.

Research Objectives:

This study aims to completely investigate how social media usage affects the academic performance of university students. It will look at both the amount of time spent on social media and the reasons for usage to determine whether certain behaviors are more harmful or beneficial. The study will also analyze how this effect differs across gender, year level, and course of study.

Significance of the Study:

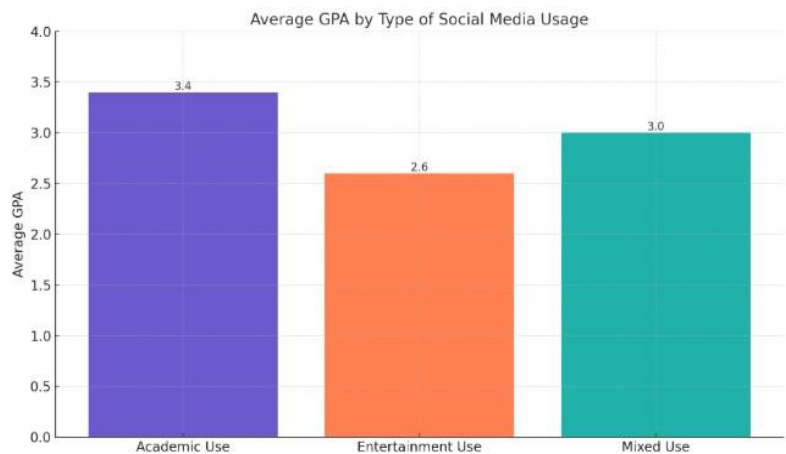
Understanding the impact of social media on student performance will help educators and policymakers to develop guidelines that promote healthy digital behavior. It can also inform students themselves about the possible consequences of unregulated social media activity on their academic success.

Methodology:

This study used a quantitative approach to collect and analyze data regarding social media usage and academic performance. A structured questionnaire was distributed to 200 university students across different faculties, including Arts, Science, Engineering, and Business. The participants were selected randomly, and the survey was conducted online using Google Forms.

The questionnaire consists of questions about their GPA, study habits, and purposes of social media usage (e.g., academic, social, entertainment). The data were coded and entered into Excel, then analyzed using basic statistical tools such as mean, percentage, and correlation coefficient.

Data Analysis:



Usage Type	Percentage of Students (%)	Average GPA
Academic Use	22%	3.4
Entertainment Use	68%	2.6
Mixed Use	10%	3.0

The bar chart indicates that students who primarily use social media for academic purposes have the highest average GPA (3.4), whereas those who use it for entertainment purposes score lower (2.6). Mixed users fall in between with a GPA of 3.0. This suggests that purposeful, academic use of social media may support better academic performance, while excessive entertainment use could be a distraction.

Conclusion:

The findings of this study suggest that social media have both positive and negative impacts on students' academic performance. While it can be very useful for sharing academic resources and encouraging collaboration among classmates, overuse for entertainment purposes can lead to time wastage, low concentration, and poorer academic results. The issue is not only the amount of time spent online, but also the purpose and nature of that usage.

Many students are not fully aware of how their digital habits influence their study outcomes. As a result, there is a need for educational institutions to develop awareness programs that teach responsible and productive use of social media. Workshops, guidance sessions, and digital literacy courses can help students to better manage their online activity.

This study concluded that the effects of social media are not entirely positive or negative, but rather depend on individual behaviors and context. Further research is needed to explore deeper dimensions such as long-term effects, emotional impacts, and differences between academic fields. Only through such understanding can proper strategies be formed to help students succeed in a digital age.